

HOUSTON HOME BUYER DUE DILIGENCE GUIDE

The official data sources and research tools every Houston home buyer should verify before going under contract.

Schools	Crime & Safety	Property Records
Flood & Drainage	Utilities	Transportation
Government	Health & Air Quality	Recreation
Market Data	Cost of Living	HOA & Deed Restrictions



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This guide is provided as a public educational resource. It directs buyers to public data sources for independent research. The conclusions you draw are yours to make — based on your research and what matters most to your family. Always consult qualified professionals for legal, tax, structural, and insurance questions specific to your situation.

01 Schools & Education

TEA ratings · school boundaries · test scores

SCHOOL RATINGS & RESEARCH

Texas Education Agency (TEA)

tea.texas.gov

Official state accountability scores and school report cards

GreatSchools

greatschools.org

School ratings, parent reviews, and comparison tools

Niche

niche.com

School rankings with student and parent reviews

Texas Tribune School Explorer

schools.texastribune.org

Per-student spending and financial data for every Texas dist...

SCHOOL BOUNDARY TOOLS

Precisely School Locator

school-locator.precisely.com

Address-specific school zone finder for any Texas address

02 Crime & Safety

Mapping tools · registered offenders · incident data

CRIME MAPPING TOOLS

CrimeMapping.com

crimemapping.com

Interactive crime map updated regularly by local law enforce...

SpotCrime

spotcrime.com

Crime incident map and email alert subscription

Neighbors by Ring

neighbors.ring.com

Community safety reports and real-time incident alerts

SEX OFFENDER REGISTRY

Texas DPS Sex Offender Registry

offender.txdps.state.tx.us

State database — search by address radius

03 Property Records

Appraisal district · permits · title history · CLUE reports

APPRAISAL & TAX RECORDS

HCAD — Harris County Appraisal District

hcad.org

Assessed value, tax history, lot size, improvement details

Fort Bend CAD

fbcad.org

Fort Bend County property records

Montgomery CAD

mcad-tx.org

Montgomery County property records

PERMITS & TITLE HISTORY

Harris County Clerk Real Property Search

cclerk.hctx.net

Deed history, liens, deed restrictions, and HOA documents

City of Houston Permit Office

permits.houstontx.gov

Building permit history — check for unpermitted work

INSURANCE CLAIM HISTORY

04 Flood & Drainage

FEMA maps · Harris County flood data · elevation · claim history

FEDERAL FLOOD RESOURCES

FEMA Flood Map Service Center

msc.fema.gov

Official FEMA Flood Insurance Rate Maps (FIRM) by address

FloodFactor by First Street

floodfactor.com

Property-level flood risk score with historical context

HOUSTON-SPECIFIC

Harris County Flood Control District

hcfcd.org

Local flood projects, bayou data, and Tropical Storm Harvey ...

H-GAC Flood Map Viewer

h-gac.com

Houston-Galveston Area Council regional flood visualization

ELEVATION & INSURANCE

Elevation Certificate (EC)

— ask listing agent —

Required for NFIP flood insurance; ask seller to provide or ...

05 Utilities

Electric · gas · water · rate comparison

ELECTRIC SERVICE

Power to Choose (PUCT)

powertochoose.org

Texas deregulated electricity plans comparison — use the act...

CenterPoint Energy (Delivery)

centerpointenergy.com

Transmission and distribution provider for most of Houston

GAS & WATER

Atmos Energy

atmosenergy.com

Natural gas service for most of the Houston area

City of Houston Water

houstontx.gov/water

Water quality reports and service area lookup

Municipal Utility Districts

— check with title company —

Many suburban homes are served by a MUD — call 311 or check ...

06 Transportation & Commute

Rush hour · transit · toll roads · airport proximity

COMMUTE RESEARCH TOOLS

Google Maps (commute mode)

maps.google.com

Set a recurring commute to test the actual drive at your act...

TxDOT 511 Traffic

drivetexas.org

Real-time traffic, construction, and road conditions statewi...

Waze

waze.com

Community-sourced traffic data — better for local incident a...

TRANSIT OPTIONS

METRO Trip Planner

ridemetro.org

Houston Metro bus and rail route planner

TxTag / EZ TAG

txtag.org

Toll road access — required for express lanes on I-10, 290, ...

07 Government & Municipal Services

City services · county offices · tax exemptions

EXEMPTIONS & TAX RECORDS**HCAD Homestead Exemption**hcad.org/resources/exemptions

File for homestead exemption within 12 months of purchase — ...

O'Connor Tax Reduction Specialistspoconnor.com

Annual property tax protest — contingency basis, no savings ...

MUNICIPAL INFORMATION**City of Houston Online Services**houstontx.gov

Code enforcement, permits, trash/recycling, and city services

Harris County Servicesharriscountytexas.gov

County-level services, flood control, and precinct informati...

Incorporated City Lookup

— check with title company —

Many suburban addresses are in independent cities with separ...

08 Health & Environment

Air quality · water quality · hospital proximity

AIR QUALITY**AirNow.gov**airnow.gov

EPA real-time Air Quality Index by zip code

TCEQ Air Quality Monitortceq.texas.gov/airquality

Texas Commission on Environmental Quality monitoring stations

WATER QUALITY**EWG's Tap Water Database**ewg.org/tapwater

City-by-city tap water quality reports and contaminant data

EPA Safe Drinking Waterepa.gov/ground-water-and-drinking-water

Federal water quality standards and local utility compliance

MEDICAL FACILITIES**Hospital Compare (CMS)**medicare.gov/hospitalcompare

Hospital quality ratings — know what is near you before you ...

09 Recreation & Lifestyle

Parks · trails · libraries · community amenities

PARKS & OUTDOORS**Houston Parks & Recreation**houstontx.gov/parks

City park locations, trails, aquatic centers, and programs

Harris County Precinct Parkshcp4.net

County-managed parks and recreational facilities

Texas Parks & Wildlifetpwd.texas.gov

State parks and outdoor recreation across Texas

LIBRARIES**Houston Public Library**houstonlibrary.org

44 locations across the city — cards are free with proof of ...

Harris County Public Libraryhcpl.net

26 branches throughout unincorporated Harris County

10 Real Estate Market Data

Sales trends · price per sq ft · days on market

MARKET REPORTS**Houston Association of Realtors (HAR)**har.com/content/market-data

Monthly market reports and MLS statistics for every Houston ...

Texas A&M Real Estate Centerrecenter.tamu.edu

Statewide real estate research, forecasts, and economic data

11 Cost of Living

City-to-city comparison calculators

COMPARISON TOOLS**BestPlaces Cost of Living Calculator**bestplaces.net/cost_of_living

Compare living costs between cities and neighborhoods side b...

Numbeo Cost of Living Indexnumbeo.com/cost-of-living

Crowdsourced cost data — useful for international relocation...

12 HOA & Deed Restrictions

Governing documents · fees · option period checklist

HOA RESEARCH**Harris County Clerk Real Property**cclerk.hctx.net/Applications/WebSearch/R...

Search deed restrictions and HOA governing documents

Contact the Listing Agent

— ask directly —

Request HOA management company contact and financial documen...

Review During Option Period

— your 7-10 day window —

Budget, bylaws, rules, meeting minutes, and reserve fund — r...

PRO RESEARCH TIPS

Six habits that separate well-prepared buyers from the ones who get surprised after closing



Cross-Reference Everything

No single source has the complete picture. If flood data from FEMA and FloodFactor disagree, dig deeper — they may be measuring different things.



Check the Date on Data

Market conditions change. Crime stats are updated on different schedules. Always check when the data was last refreshed before drawing conclusions.



Drive the Neighborhood at Different Times

Tuesday at 7:30am is a different neighborhood than Sunday at noon. Drive both. The commute, the noise, the traffic pattern — these are things no database captures.



Drive the Commute During Rush Hour

Seriously. Not on a map app. In your car. At the time you will actually do it. There is no substitute for experiencing the actual drive before you commit to the address.



Talk to the Neighbors

If you can manage a brief conversation with someone on the street, do it. People who live there know things — about the HOA, the flooding two streets over, the development coming in — that official sources will never tell you.



Check Nextdoor and Local Facebook Groups

Community social media surfaces the real texture of a neighborhood: what people complain about, what they celebrate, what they are worried about. Search before you decide.

A NOTE ABOUT THIS GUIDE

This guide directs you to public resources so you can do your own independent research. It does not provide opinions about specific neighborhoods, crime levels, school quality, or flood safety — those conclusions are yours to draw, based on your research and what matters most to your family. For legal, tax, structural, and insurance questions specific to any property, always consult the appropriate licensed professional.

Questions? Ready to start your search?

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